doubtless reaching out to those with whom India already had trade and even political links. In Edict XIII, Ashoka refers to missions he sent ‘to the Yona (Greek) king Antiyoka (Antiochos II of Syria, 261–246 BC), Turamaya (Ptolemais II Philadelphos, 285–247 BC), Antikini (Antigonos Gonatas of Macedonia, 276–239 BC), Maka (Magas of Cyrene, 300–250 BC) and Alikasudara (probably Alexander of Epirus 272–255 BC)’.

In South East Asia we still see the deep imprint of the long-standing and close interaction that took place with India for centuries, until these links were severed by the rise of European colonialism. India’s engagement with its South East Asian neighbourhood was extraordinary in its scope, covering political, economic, cultural, religious and social activity. It spanned a vast expanse of time, resulting in a rich layering of mutual influences. The Bali Yatra in Odisha still celebrates what must have been regular sailings from India to the Indonesian archipelago in the past.

There is a misperception in some circles that South East Asia got all its culture and art from India. Throughout the region one does encounter the colours and sounds of India but the cultural assets borrowed from it were transformed into exquisite works of local genius and creativity. Each side stimulated the imagination of the other, each encounter triggered an efflorescence of creative innovation. For India, much of South East Asia was ‘Suvarnabhumi’, the land of gold. Indian textiles and designs travelled to the region, and designs and motifs from the region influenced Indian designs and techniques. The Ramayana and the Mahabharata became popular in Myanmar, Thailand, Cambodia and Indonesia, their basic narratives often embellished with local legends and characters. One can see this in the spectacular performance of the Ramayana at the Prambanan temple in Jogjakarta, where local genius has added flavours and colours that are uniquely Indonesian.

It is only now that India is reconnecting with this neighbourhood, at once familiar yet with a proud identity of its own.

Indian engagement over the centuries has stretched to China’s eastern seaboard and to Japan and Korea. In the eighth century CE , it was an Indian Brahmin priest, Bodhisena, then serving in the kingdom of Cambodge